



ISBNPA

Advancing Behavior Change Science

AUCKLAND, NEW ZEALAND

11 - 14 JUNE, 2025



Using participatory methods to identify barriers for physical activity and healthy diets in a deprived local community: a case study in Flanders

Jessie Van Kerckhove

Sciensano & Ghent University, Belgium

Jessie Van Kerckhove, Maïté Verloigne, Leonor Guariguata and Stefanie Vandevijvere

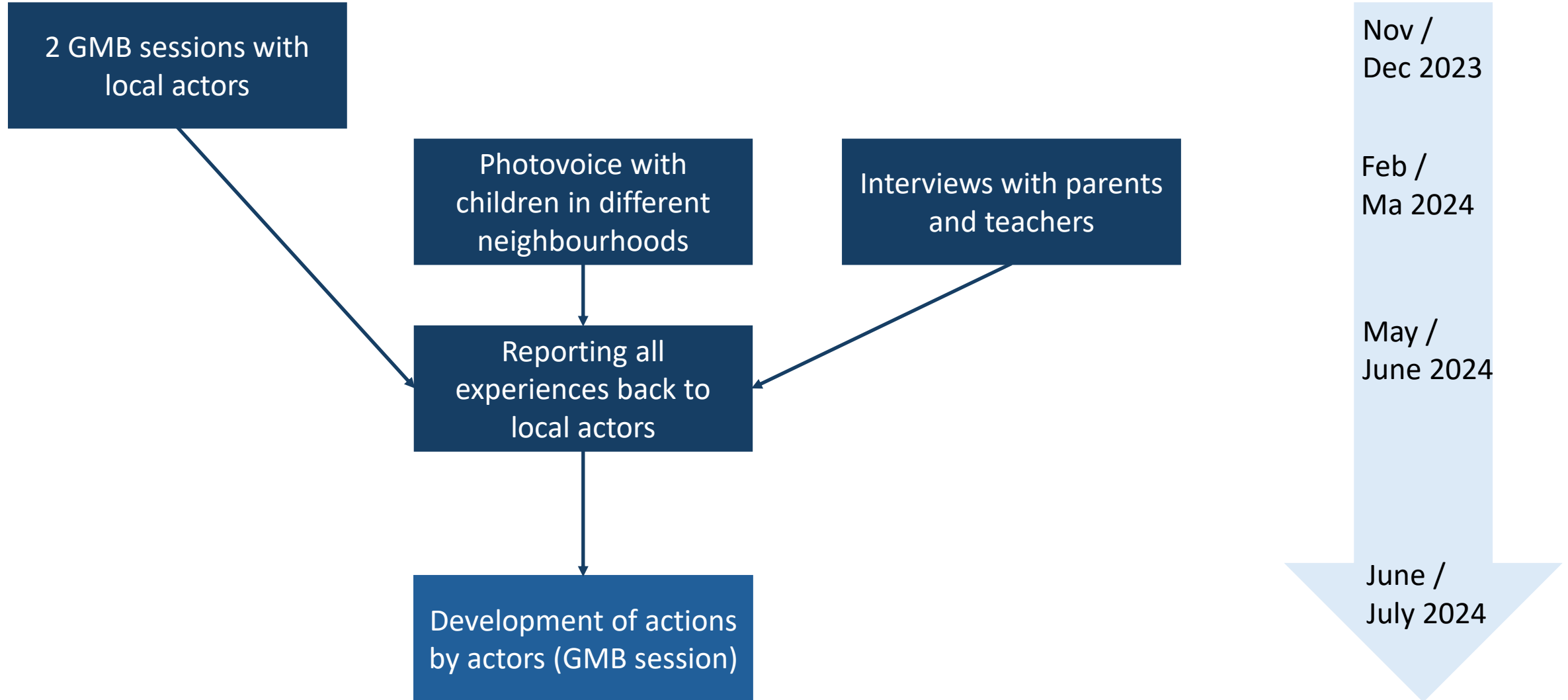
Background

Case study: Maasmechelen, Flanders (Belgium)



Neighbourhood	Population size (% from total population in city)	Density (pop./km ²)	Average taxable net income* p.p. (€)	Population with low education level (%)**	Food swamp score (0-10) ***
Mariaheide	2796	3997	15.225	46,2	1.8
Klein Spanje	1096	1457	16.475	44,9	0
Vrijheide	1046	2314	14.516	54,3	0.5
Beremsheuvel	1137	5443	13.322	49,3	2.6
MAASMECHELEN (entire city)	39.914	519	17.775	39,3	1.7
FLANDERS	6.774.807	497	21.731	31,2	-

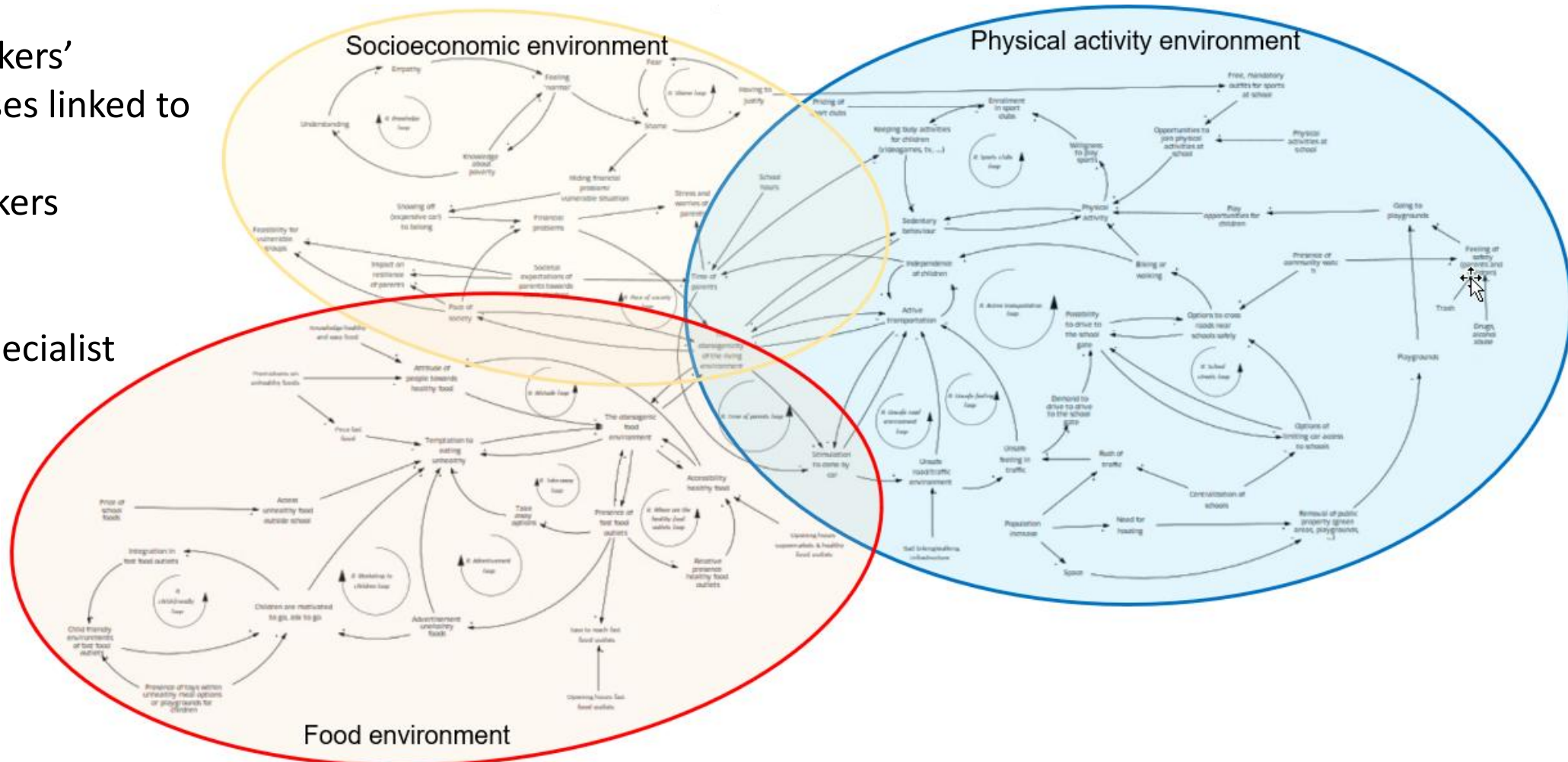
Methodology needs assessment



Group model building with local actors

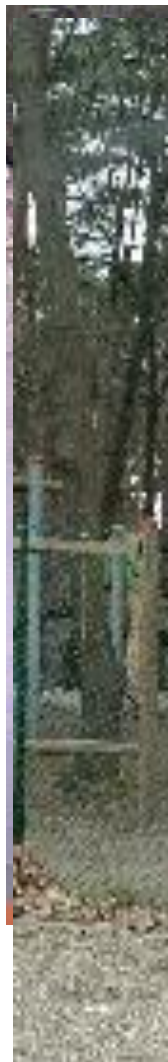
OUR NETWORK

- Local government officials
- Specialists from 'Gezondheidsmakers'
- Doctors and nurses linked to school services
- Youth social workers
- Health insurance representatives
- Mental health specialist



Ph

OUR CH



Interviews with parents & teachers

Physical activity environment

- Focus on road safety
- Focus on opportunities for play
- Focus on (limitations) of school environments

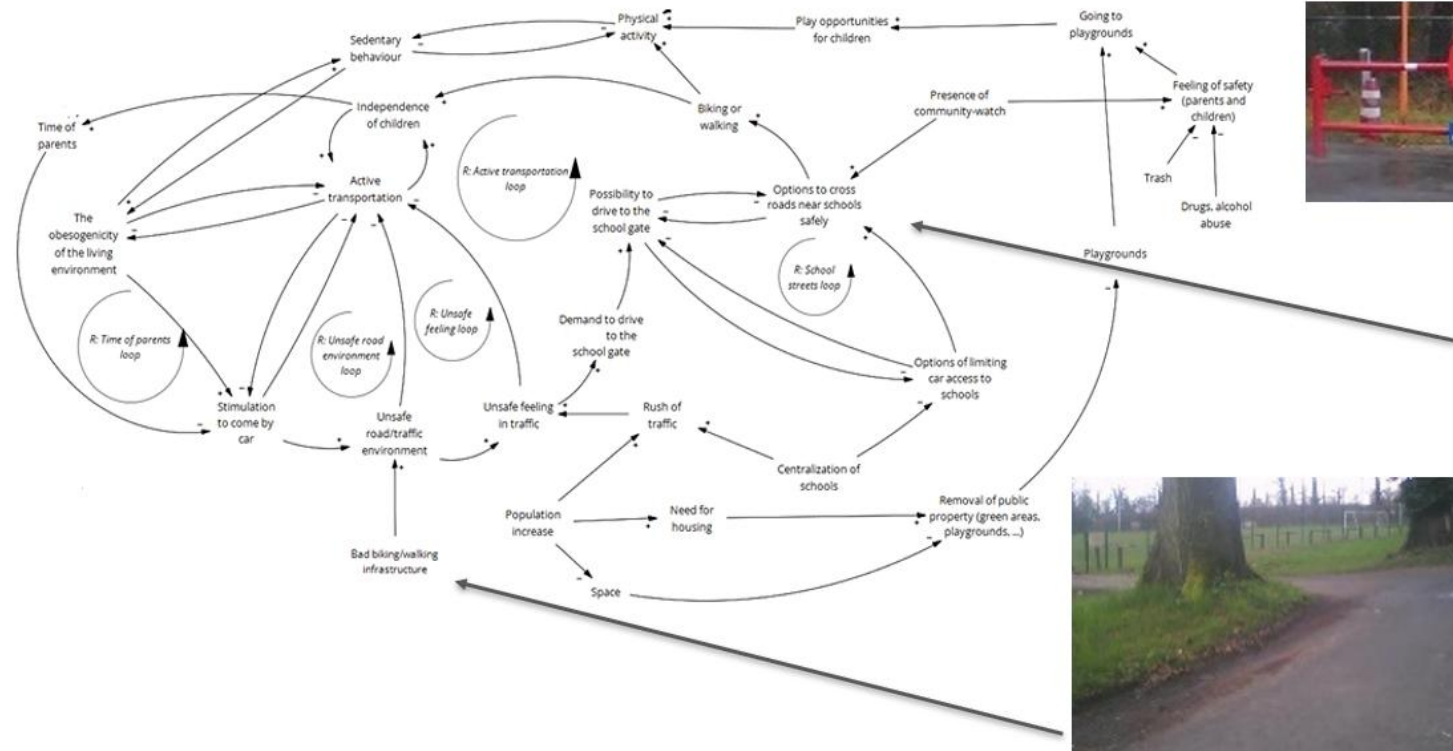
Food environment

- Focus on lack of healthy options throughout the municipality
- Focus on unhealthy or empty lunch boxes
- Focus on parent resistance

Reporting all experiences back

Results

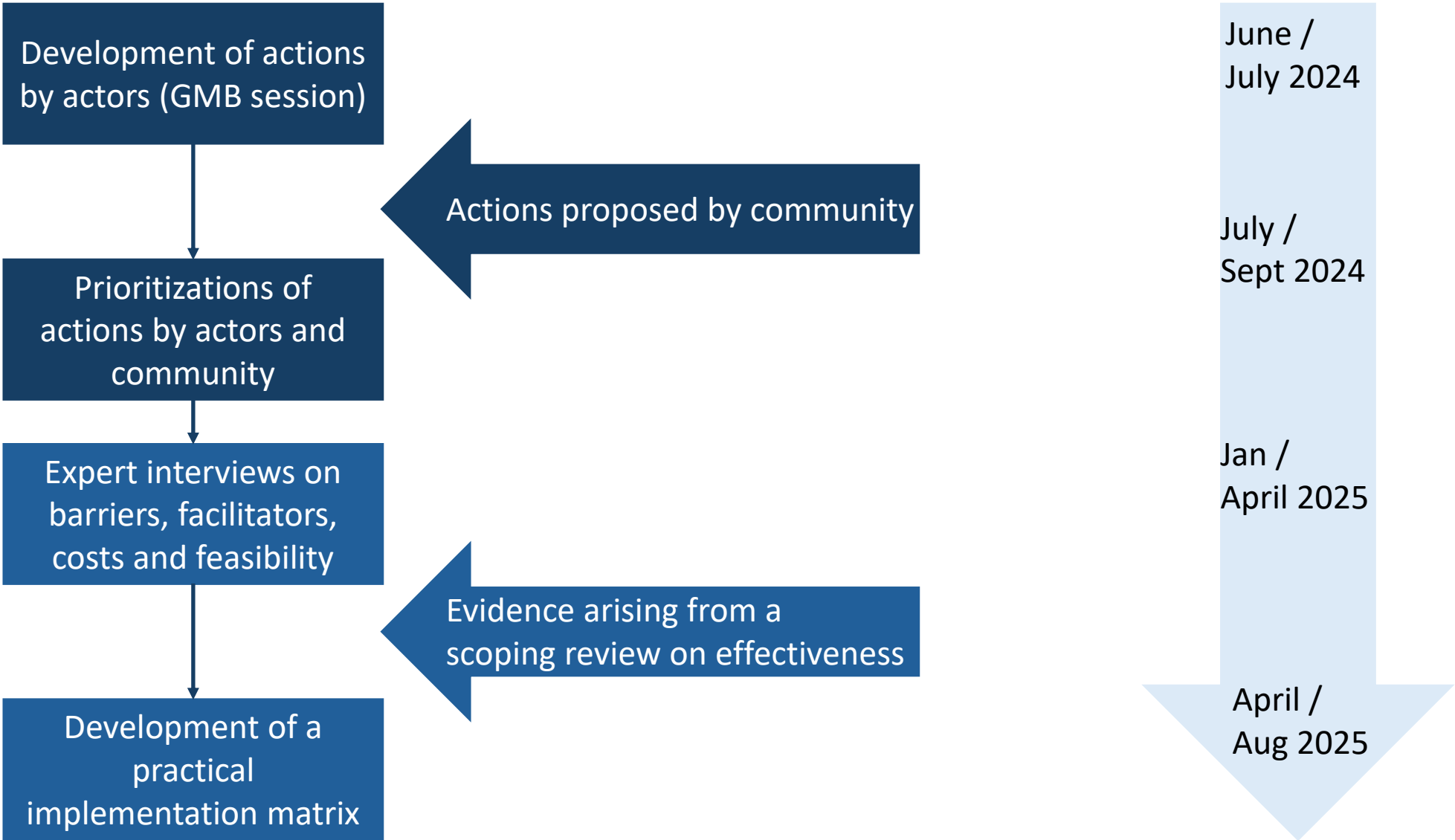
- Shared understanding of the barriers
 - Understanding why certain actions (do not) work
 - Understanding of difficulties for groups in vulnerable situations
 - Positive view on how policy and environment can contribute to reducing health inequalities by investing in access to healthy foods and opportunities for physical activity
- 56 targeted actions



Development of actions by actors

Theme	Possible places to intervene	Proposed actions
Theme 1: Food and the food environment		
Food and the food environment at school	(V) Accessibility healthy food <i>Where are the healthy food outlets loop?</i>	- Offer hot (healthy) meals at school - Offer free fruit or soup at school - 'Let's make soup together'-day - Too good to go for fruits and vegetables at school, in collaboration with local vendors and supermarkets
	(V) Price of school foods	- Healthy breakfast at school (with or without parents)
	(V) Access unhealthy food outside school (V) Presence of fast food outlets <i>Take away loop; Where are the healthy food outlets loop?</i>	- Restrictions on the opening hours of fast-food outlets - Restrictions on leaving the school property during lunch hours to avoid students going to fast food outlets
	(V) Opening hours fast food outlets	
	(V) Knowledge healthy and easy food (V) Attitude of people towards healthy food <i>Attitude loop</i>	- Cooking classes at school - Work together with dieticians to inform parents and children about a healthy (payable) lunch box - Health walk, inspired by the national guidelines for food and physical activity

Next steps: implementation



Output: practical implementation matrix

Action	Barriers	Facilitators	Cost calculation	Expected outcome	(International) evidence
Offer (free) soup at school	Logistics (preparation, brining soup to schools, dishes, ...)	Social employment	To be determined	Positive impact on children that do not have enough access to healthy food	No local implementation found in studies
	Stigmatization if not universally free but with reduced pricing scheme & Not accessible to those who will need it most when not free	Willingness from schools		Positive impact on attitude towards vegetables	Other Flemish cities have successfully introduced this concept
	16 kindergartens and primary schools in Maasmechelen – too much to implement all at once	Subsidies from Flemish governments to cover part of the costs		Positive impact for complying with national nutrition recommendations	
	Budget			Positive impact on parents	
	Dietary restrictions for different cultural groups			Negative impact on budget	
	How to ensure healthy soup (enough vegetables, limit salt content)?			Feasibility of this action deemed high	
	Time to eat in primary schools is limited				
	Extra burden for lunch-monitor volunteers				

Reflection

Strengths

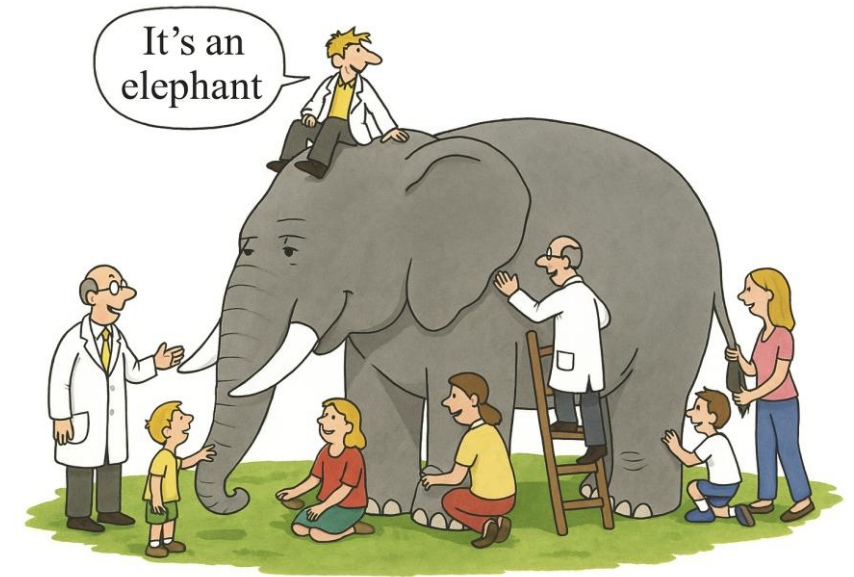
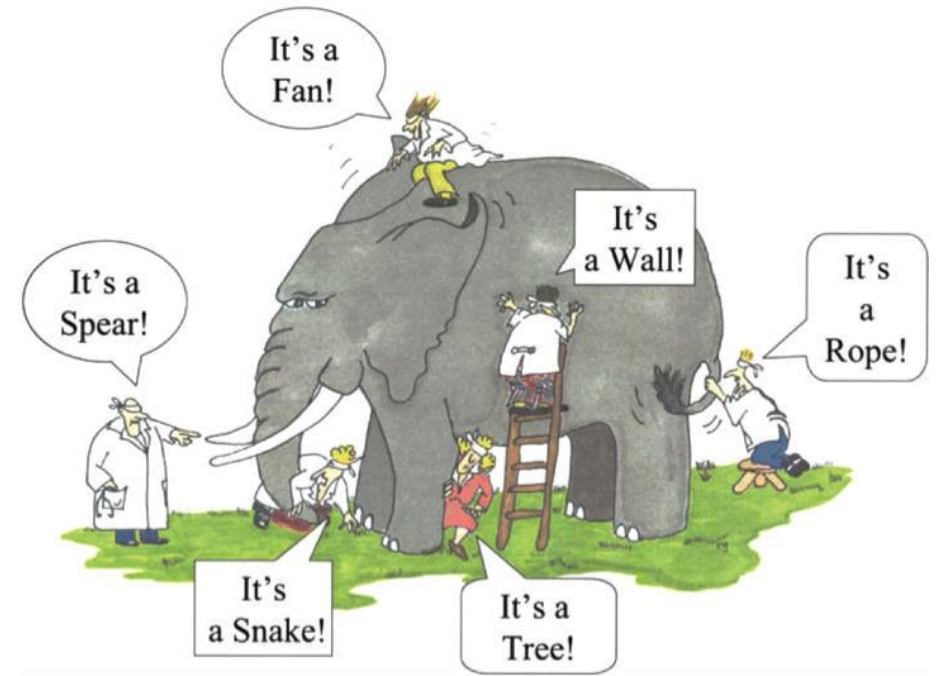
- Interdisciplinary health network
- Inclusion of children of different ages and backgrounds
- Intercept interviews to engage parents
- Researcher as independent factor between community and actors

Limitations

- Organisation of photovoice with schools
= focus mainly on school environment
- Recruitment of children experiencing vulnerable situations = difficult
=> use of trusted social workers (inclusion of their opinion?)
- Limited time with actors

Conclusion

- Combination of age-appropriate methods
- Highlighted barriers from different points of view
- Created understanding
- Offering an example for other local governments



Acknowledgements

This project is part of the Joint Action **Health4EuKids**,
co-funded by the **European Union, Health and Digital Executive Office**
(Grant 101082462)



*A joint action for the implementation of best practices and research results
on Healthy Lifestyle for the health promotion and prevention of non-
communicable diseases and risk factors*





ISBNPA

Advancing Behavior Change Science

AUCKLAND, NEW ZEALAND

11 - 14 JUNE, 2025



THANK YOU